

STERLING & CO. PROPERTIES

Real Estate Website Project Proposal

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Organisation: Sterling & Co. Properties

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Your Next Property Starts Here

1. Organisation Overview

Field	Detail
Organisation	Sterling & Co. Properties
Industry	Real Estate & Property Sales
Location	Cape Town, Western Cape, South Africa
Category	Full-Service Residential & Commercial Brokerage
Website Status	New Development Required

1.1 Brief History

Sterling & Co. Properties was established in 2011 in Cape Town, Western Cape, South Africa. Founded by the Nene family with a vision to make property buying, selling, and renting transparent and stress-free, the agency began as a two-person office serving the Southern Suburbs. Over the years, it expanded into a full-service brokerage with 34 agents, covering residential, commercial, and holiday-rental portfolios across the greater Cape Town metropolitan area.

By 2019, Sterling & Co. Properties had earned multiple regional industry awards, including Top Independent Agency in the Western Cape. The agency has undergone two major rebranding exercises in 2016 and 2023 to modernise its market positioning while preserving its reputation for meticulous, client-first service. It is a proud member of the Estate Agency Affairs Board (EAAB) and the Real Estate Business Owners of South Africa (REBOSA).

1.2 Mission Statement

“To guide every client through the property journey with honesty, expertise, and genuine care, turning transactions into long-term relationships.”

1.3 Vision Statement

“To be the most trusted independent property brokerage on the South African coastline, recognised for integrity, market insight, and client advocacy.”

1.4 Target Audience

- First-time buyers and young professionals entering the property market
- Homeowners looking to sell or upgrade to a larger property
- Investors seeking rental yield and capital growth opportunities
- Commercial tenants and landlords seeking office, retail, or industrial space
- Families relocating within or into the Western Cape
- International buyers and semigration clients from other provinces

2. Website Goals and Objectives

2.1 Primary Goals

- Increase qualified buyer and seller leads generated directly through the website, reducing reliance on third-party property portals (e.g., Property24, Private Property) and their listing fees
- Establish a strong digital brand presence that reflects the agency's professionalism and market expertise
- Provide prospective clients with comprehensive, accurate, and easily searchable property listings
- Generate qualified leads for property valuations and seller mandates
- Improve search engine visibility for target keywords in the Cape Town property market

2.2 Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

KPI Metric	Baseline	Target (Month 3)	Growth Target (Month 12)
Monthly Website Visitors	2,000 unique visitors	6,000 unique visitors	15,000 unique visitors
Property Enquiry Submissions	15 enquiries/month	60 enquiries/month	150 enquiries/month
Bounce Rate	Below 60%	Below 45%	Below 35%
Average Session Duration	1 min 15 sec	3 min+	4 min+
Valuation Requests	5/month	20/month	50/month
Search Engine Ranking	—	Top 10 for key terms	Top 3 for key terms
Mobile Traffic Share	48% of total traffic	55% of total traffic	65% of total traffic

3. Current Website Analysis

Sterling & Co. Properties currently operates a basic informational website created in 2018. The following analysis has been conducted to inform the redesign process.

3.1 Strengths of the Existing Website

- Contains basic contact information and office address
- Includes a property gallery with some high-quality listing imagery
- Lists available properties with general price ranges
- Has a functioning contact form for general enquiries

3.2 Weaknesses and Areas for Improvement

- No integrated property search with filters for price, suburb, bedrooms, or property type

- Poor mobile responsiveness; the site is not optimised for smartphones or tablets
- Outdated visual design that does not reflect the agency's current professional branding
- Slow page load times due to uncompressed images and legacy code
- No search engine optimisation (SEO) strategy in place
- Absence of a blog or market-insights section to drive organic traffic
- No live chat or WhatsApp integration for prospective client support
- Missing agent profile pages and client testimonial integration
- No mortgage/bond calculator or seller valuation request section

4. Proposed Website Features and Functionality

4.1 Core Pages

- Homepage — Hero banner, key value propositions, featured listings, testimonials, and CTAs
- About Us — Agency history, agent profiles, awards, and accreditations
- Property Listings — Searchable and filterable grid of residential and commercial properties
- Property Detail Pages — Individual listing pages with photo galleries, floor plans, and enquiry forms
- Suburb Guides — Area profiles, amenities, schools, and market trend summaries
- Sell With Us — Valuation request form, marketing process overview, and seller FAQs
- Commercial Property — Office, retail, and industrial listings with specification tables
- Our Agents — Individual agent profiles, specialisations, and direct contact details
- Market Insights / Blog — Property trends, buying and selling tips, and local news for SEO
- Contact Us — Map integration, contact form, WhatsApp button, and live chat

4.2 Key Functionality

- Property Search Engine — Advanced filtering by price, suburb, bedrooms, property type, and listing status
- Mobile-First Responsive Design — Fully optimised across all device types
- SEO Optimisation — Structured data, meta tags, sitemap, and Google Analytics integration
- Bond / Mortgage Calculator — Interactive repayment estimator for prospective buyers
- Review Aggregator — Google Reviews and testimonial widget

- WhatsApp Chat Button — Direct messaging for instant client support
- Newsletter Subscription — Email capture with Mailchimp integration for new-listing alerts
- Saved Searches & Property Alerts — Registered users can save searches and receive email notifications

- ## 5. Design and User Experience

5.1 Design Aesthetic and Branding

- The website design will reflect Sterling & Co. Properties' identity: understated, editorial sophistication conveyed through a disciplined black-and-white palette. The visual language will communicate credibility, precision, and calm authority appealing to discerning buyers, sellers, and investors.

Attribute	Detail
Design Style	Monochrome Editorial with Architectural Minimalism
Inspiration	Fine-line architectural drawings, gallery-style photography framing, newsprint typography
Aesthetic	Clean, high-contrast layout reminiscent of premium architecture and design publications

5.2 Colour Scheme

The palette is intentionally restricted to black, white, and greyscale tones no colour is used anywhere in the interface. Emphasis and hierarchy are created through contrast, weight, and whitespace rather than colour.

Swatch	Hex	Role
Ink Black	#000000	Primary text, headings, primary buttons
Charcoal	#404040	Secondary headings, navigation
Steel Grey	#808080	Borders, dividers, muted text
Fog Grey	#D9D9D9	Card backgrounds, table shading
Paper White	#FFFFFF	Primary background

5.3 Typography

Role	Font / Specification
Primary Heading Font	Aptos — Editorial serif for agency name, page titles, and hero text
Secondary Heading Font	Aptos (Bold) — Clean sans-serif for section headings
Body Copy Font	Aptos (Regular/Light) — Highly readable for descriptions and listing content
Accent / CTA Font	Aptos (Bold, uppercase tracking) — Used for buttons and labels
Font Hierarchy	H1: 44–60px H2: 30–34px H3: 22–24px Body: 16px Captions: 13px

5.4 Layout and Design Approach

- Full-screen hero photograph on the homepage, rendered in high-contrast black and white with an overlay search widget
- Grid-based listing display with hover effects revealing key property details and a direct 'View Property' CTA
- Sticky navigation bar that transitions from transparent to solid black on scroll
- Generous whitespace to create a premium, uncluttered feel
- Asymmetric editorial layouts in the About and Suburb Guide sections for visual interest
- Full-bleed image sections alternating with text panels for visual rhythm, all rendered in monochrome

5.5 User Experience Considerations

- Navigation — Maximum three-click depth to any page; primary navigation with clear dropdown menus
- Accessibility — WCAG 2.1 AA compliant; high colour contrast by design, alt text for all images, keyboard navigation
- Enquiry Flow — Streamlined 3-step enquiry process: Find Property → View Details → Request Viewing / Valuation
- Page Load Speed — Target under 2.5 seconds; lazy image loading, CDN implementation

- Trust Signals — Prominently displayed accreditation badges, agent credentials, and client testimonials
- **5.6 Low-Fidelity Wireframes — Key Screens**

Page	Layout Description
Homepage	Top: Sticky navbar Hero: Full-screen monochrome image with search widget overlay Below: USP strip (3 icons) Featured Listings grid Testimonials carousel Market Insights strip Footer
Property Listings	Top: Navbar Breadcrumb Filter bar (type, price, suburb, bedrooms) Listing card grid (image, name, price, CTA) Sidebar: Saved search widget Footer
Property Detail	Top: Full-width image gallery (8 images) Property title & highlights Specifications list Bond calculator & enquiry CTA Similar Properties strip Footer
Contact Page	Top: Navbar Contact info cards (3 columns: Phone, Email, Office) Embedded map Contact form WhatsApp CTA button Footer

6. Technical Requirements

6.1 Hosting and Domain

Item	Detail
Domain Name	www.sterlingproperties.co.za (or .com)
Domain Registrar	Domains.co.za or Afrihost (South African registrar recommended)
Hosting Type	Cloud VPS Hosting — recommended for performance and scalability
Hosting Provider	Afrihost or Hetzner South Africa (local CDN for low latency)
SSL Certificate	Let's Encrypt (Free) or Comodo Positive SSL — mandatory for enquiry and valuation forms
Email Hosting	Professional email (e.g., info@sterlingproperties.co.za) via Zoho Mail or G Suite
CDN	Cloudflare — for performance, security, and South African edge servers
Backup	Daily automated backups with 30-day retention

6.2 Technology Stack

Layer	Specification
Frontend	HTML5, CSS3 (with CSS Variables & Grid/Flexbox), JavaScript (ES6+)
CSS Framework	Tailwind CSS — for rapid, consistent utility-based styling
Frontend Framework	React.js (Next.js) — for server-side rendering and SEO benefits
Backend / CMS	WordPress with Elementor Pro — for ease of content management
Listings Engine	Custom API integration with the Property24 / Private Property syndication feed, or a dedicated IDX-style plugin
Payment Gateway	Not required for core site; PayFast integration reserved for future premium-listing features
Database	MySQL (via WordPress) with Redis caching
Version Control	Git (GitHub) — for codebase management and collaboration
Analytics	Google Analytics 4 + Google Search Console + Hotjar (heatmaps)
Accessibility	WCAG 2.1 AA compliance tools: axe DevTools and Lighthouse audits

7. Timeline and Milestones

The following project timeline outlines a realistic 16-week development schedule from project initiation to live deployment:

Phase	Milestone	Duration / Date
Phase 1	Project Kick-off: Brief finalisation, stakeholder sign-off, NDA & contracts	Week 1
Phase 1	Discovery & Research: Competitor analysis, user research, listings audit	Week 2
Phase 2	Information Architecture: Sitemap, user flows, and content strategy	Week 3
Phase 2	Wireframes: Low-fidelity wireframes for all key pages (client review)	Week 4
Phase 3	Brand & Style Guide: Monochrome palette, typography, UI component library	Week 5
Phase 3	High-Fidelity Mockups: Visual designs for Homepage, Listings, Contact pages	Week 6–7
Phase 3	Client Design Review & Approval — Revision round included	Week 8
Phase 4	Frontend Development: HTML/CSS/JS, responsive implementation	Week 9–10
Phase 4	CMS Integration: WordPress setup, content entry, listings engine	Week 11–12
Phase 5	Backend & Integrations: Listings feed, email, analytics setup	Week 13
Phase 5	Quality Assurance: Cross-browser, cross-device, accessibility, speed tests	Week 14

Phase	Milestone	Duration / Date
Phase 5	User Acceptance Testing (UAT): Client walkthrough and feedback	Week 15
Phase 6	Launch Preparation: DNS migration, SSL, staging to live deployment	Week 16
Phase 6	Post-Launch Support: Bug fixes, performance monitoring, handover training	Weeks 17–18

8. Budget Estimate

The following budget estimate is based on current South African market rates for professional web development, hosting, and ongoing maintenance. All amounts are in South African Rand (ZAR) and inclusive of VAT.

Category	Description	Estimated Cost (ZAR)
Discovery	Project research, competitor analysis, listings audit, information architecture	R 8,500.00
Design	UI/UX design, wireframes, high-fidelity mockups, style guide, 2 revision rounds	R 21,000.00
Development	Frontend & backend development, CMS setup, listings engine integration	R 68,000.00
Integrations	Listings feed, Google Analytics, CRM, WhatsApp, bond calculator	R 13,500.00
Content	Professional photography (1-day shoot), copywriting (all pages), image optimisation	R 20,700.00
SEO Setup	On-page SEO, keyword strategy, Google Business Profile, sitemap submission	R 6,500.00

Category	Description	Estimated Cost (ZAR)
Testing	QA testing, accessibility audit, cross-browser/device testing, performance audit	R 5,000.00
Hosting	VPS hosting (1 year) — Hetzner South Africa, SSL certificate, CDN (Cloudflare)	R 4,800.00
Domain	Domain registration (.co.za) for 2 years, email hosting setup	R 1,200.00
Training	CMS training for agency staff (2 sessions), user manual documentation	R 3,500.00
Maintenance	6-month post-launch support, security updates, performance monitoring	R 9,600.00

TOTAL ESTIMATED BUDGET: R 162,300.00

Budget Notes

- Ongoing monthly maintenance after the initial 6-month period is estimated at R 1,600/month
- Photography budget may increase if drone/aerial footage is required (additional R 4,500)
- Paid advertising (Google Ads, Meta Ads) is not included and is recommended as a separate marketing budget
- All quoted amounts are estimates; final pricing subject to formal scope agreement

9. References

The following references informed the research and recommendations in this proposal:

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Part 2 Update — CSS Styling and Responsive Design

Part 2 of the website build involved creating an external CSS stylesheet and applying responsive design across the site's five pages (Home, About Us, Properties & Services, Enquiry, Contact).

1. External Stylesheet

- Created css/style.css and linked it to all five HTML pages using `<link rel="stylesheet">`
- Applied a browser-consistent CSS reset (box-sizing, margin/padding normalisation, list and image defaults) as the base style
- Established CSS custom properties (variables) for colour, typography, spacing, radius and shadow values, so styling is consistent and easy to update across every page from one place

2. Typography

- Implemented a two-typeface system: a serif display face (Fraunces) for headings paired with a sans-serif (Public Sans) for body text
- Used rem units and clamp() for a fluid type scale that adjusts smoothly between mobile and desktop screen sizes

3. Layout Structure

- Used CSS Grid for card-based layouts: featured/current property listings, service cards, team member profiles and the footer columns
- Used Flexbox for the header and navigation bar, and for the hero section
- Applied a consistent spacing system (container width, section padding, gaps) using the custom properties defined in 10.1

4. Visual Styling and Interactivity

- Styled buttons, cards, the service comparison table, and all form fields using colour, borders, border-radius and box-shadow
- Added :hover, :focus and :focus-visible states to navigation links, buttons, cards and form fields, both for interactivity and keyboard-accessibility

5. Responsive Design

- Implemented two breakpoints using media queries: a tablet breakpoint (max-width: 1024px) and a mobile breakpoint (max-width: 640px)
- Multi-column Grid layouts collapse to two columns, then a single column, as the screen narrows
- The navigation bar converts to a hamburger-triggered mobile menu below 640px
- The Service Packages table on the Properties & Services page restructures into a stacked, labelled card layout on mobile instead of a horizontally scrolling table

- Relative units (rem, %, and clamp()) are used throughout for spacing, sizing and typography so the layout scales rather than breaking at fixed widths

6. Supporting JavaScript

- Added js/script.js, covering: the mobile navigation toggle (hamburger menu open/close), a dynamically generated footer copyright year, and front-end validation feedback (success messages) on the Contact and Enquiry forms

7. Colour Palette

The CSS implementation currently uses a navy-and-gold colour palette for visual hierarchy (buttons, accents, prices).